



# Pity, Fear, and Catharsis: Reverse-Engineering Tragedy with Aristotle

An original lesson plan inspired by **Aristotle (trans. S. H. Butcher)**'s *The Poetics* (Project Gutenberg). Not affiliated with or endorsed by Project Gutenberg or Aristotle (trans. S. H. Butcher). Explore the original course: <https://www.gutenberg.org/ebooks/1974>

## GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

## DURATION

65 minutes

## TOPICS

Aesthetics

*“Aristotle claims that watching terrible things happen to a good person on stage can be pleasurable, and even good for us — how can pity and fear, two uncomfortable emotions, add up to something he calls catharsis rather than just distress?”*

## Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Explain Aristotle's definition of tragedy and identify its six constituent parts (plot, character, thought, diction, melody, and spectacle), with plot as the most important.
- Define and locate hamartia, peripeteia, and anagnorisis within a specific tragic plot.
- Evaluate Aristotle's catharsis thesis — that tragedy produces a pleasurable purgation of pity and fear — by applying it to a modern tragic story.

## Materials Needed

- Excerpt handout with Aristotle's definition of tragedy, his ranking of the six parts, and his discussion of the best kind of tragic plot (including the Oedipus references)
- A one-page plot diagram template with slots for hamartia, peripeteia, and anagnorisis
- A short synopsis (half a page) of a modern tragic film, play, or novel the class is likely to know, for the application activity
- Whiteboard for building the six-parts chart

## Lesson Procedure

### Hook: What Makes a Story 'Tragic'?

8 min

Ask students to name a story, film, or show they'd call genuinely tragic and to explain in one sentence what makes it tragic rather than just sad. Collect a few answers on the board, noting any that mention the character's own choices or flaws versus pure bad luck — this distinction anticipates hamartia.

**Direct Instruction: The Six Parts of Tragedy**

15 min

Introduce Aristotle's definition of tragedy as an imitation of a serious, complete action, and walk through his six parts in descending order of importance: plot, character, thought, diction, melody, and spectacle. Emphasize Aristotle's controversial ranking — plot (the arrangement of the incidents) matters more than character, because tragedy imitates action and life, not people as such. Ask students whether they agree that plot should outrank character.

**Direct Instruction: Hamartia, Peripeteia, Anagnorisis, and Catharsis**

17 min

Using the Oedipus story as the running example from the excerpt, define hamartia (an error or flaw, not necessarily a moral vice, that sets the tragic events in motion), peripeteia (a reversal of fortune), and anagnorisis (a recognition, a shift from ignorance to knowledge, ideally coinciding with the peripeteia). Then introduce catharsis: Aristotle's claim that the best tragic plots arouse pity (for undeserved suffering) and fear (recognizing 'that could be me') and, through the completeness and unity of the plot, purge or clarify these emotions rather than leaving the audience simply distressed.

**Small-Group Application**

18 min

In small groups, students take the provided synopsis of a modern tragic story and fill in the plot diagram, identifying the protagonist's hamartia, the peripeteia, and the anagnorisis. Groups should also identify the specific moment they believe is designed to produce the most pity and the most fear, and whether those moments coincide.

**Closure: Does Catharsis Actually Happen?**

7 min

Reconvene and ask a few groups to report their diagrams. Push on the essential question directly: after finishing a genuinely tragic story, do students actually feel a kind of relief or clarification (Aristotle's catharsis), or does the story just leave them upset? Take a quick vote and ask both sides to justify their answer.

**Discussion Questions**

- 1 Aristotle ranks plot above character, arguing tragedy imitates action rather than people — do you agree, or does a tragedy's power actually come more from who the characters are than from what happens to them?
- 2 Is hamartia best understood as a moral flaw (like arrogance) or simply an error in judgment that any reasonable person could make? Does the difference matter for how much we pity the tragic hero?
- 3 If a tragic hero suffered a fate they clearly deserved, would Aristotle still call the effect 'tragic,' or does tragedy specifically require suffering that outweighs the person's fault?
- 4 Does catharsis describe something that actually happens to you after watching or reading a tragedy, or is it more like a theory of what tragedy ought to do, whether or not it always works?
- 5 Can a modern story be genuinely Aristotelian tragedy without a single 'noble' protagonist, given how different our sense of social rank is from ancient Athens?

**Assessment**

Students write a short essay analyzing one tragic story of their choosing (from the class synopsis or one they select) using Aristotle's framework: identifying its hamartia, peripeteia, and anagnorisis, and arguing whether the story ultimately produces catharsis or simply distress, with specific reference to Aristotle's account of pity and fear.

### Extension Activity

Have students find a modern film or show often described as a 'tragedy' and write a short comparison of how faithfully it follows Aristotle's structure, noting any of the six parts (especially plot vs. spectacle) that the work seems to prioritize differently than Aristotle recommends.

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